

THE VICTORIOUS HERO

Perseus



SIZE RANKING 24

BRIGHTEST STAR

Mirfak (α) 1.8

GENITIVE Persei

ABBREVIATION Per

HIGHEST IN SKY AT 10 P.M.

November–December

FULLY VISIBLE

90°N–31°S



Perseus is a prominent northern constellation lying in the Milky Way between Cassiopeia and Auriga. It is an original Greek constellation and represents Perseus, who was sent to slay Medusa, the Gorgon. In the sky, Perseus is depicted with his left hand holding the Gorgon's head, which is marked by Algol—Beta (β) Persei—a famous variable star (see p.276). His right hand brandishes his sword, marked by the twin clusters NGC 869 and NGC 884.

SPECIFIC FEATURES

The constellation's brightest member—Mirfak, or Alpha (α) Persei—is of magnitude 1.8. It lies at the center of a group of stars known as the Alpha Persei Cluster or Melotte 20. Scattered over an area of sky that is several times the diameter of a full moon, the cluster is an excellent sight through binoculars.

Algol is an eclipsing binary consisting of two stars in close orbit, one much hotter and brighter than the other. Together they shine at magnitude 2.1, but every 69 hours the fainter star eclipses its companion. Over a period of five hours, the combined light

of the pair drops to just one-third its normal value, a change that is readily noticeable to the naked eye. Algol's brightness returns to normal after another 5 hours. Predictions of Algol's eclipses can be found in astronomical annuals and magazines.

Rho (ρ) Persei is a variable of a different kind: it is a red giant that fluctuates by about 50 percent in brightness every 7 weeks or so.

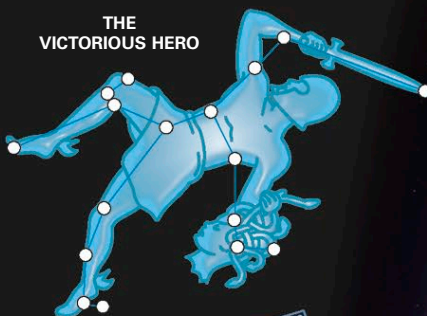
Popularly termed the Double Cluster, the twin open clusters NGC 869 and NGC 884 are one of the showpieces of the northern sky. Each cluster contains hundreds of stars of 7th magnitude and fainter, and covers an area of sky similar to that of a full moon. They lie more than 7,000 light-years away in the Perseus spiral arm of our galaxy. Both clusters are noticeable to the naked eye as a brighter patch in the Milky Way near the border with Cassiopeia and can be seen well through binoculars or a small telescope.

M34 is a scattered open cluster of several dozen stars near the border with Andromeda. It covers an apparent area similar to that of a full moon and is easy to spot through binoculars.

ALPHA PERSEI CLUSTER

Mirfak and its surrounding cluster lie above center. The Pleiades Cluster is lower right, and Capella, in Auriga, is lower left.

THE VICTORIOUS HERO



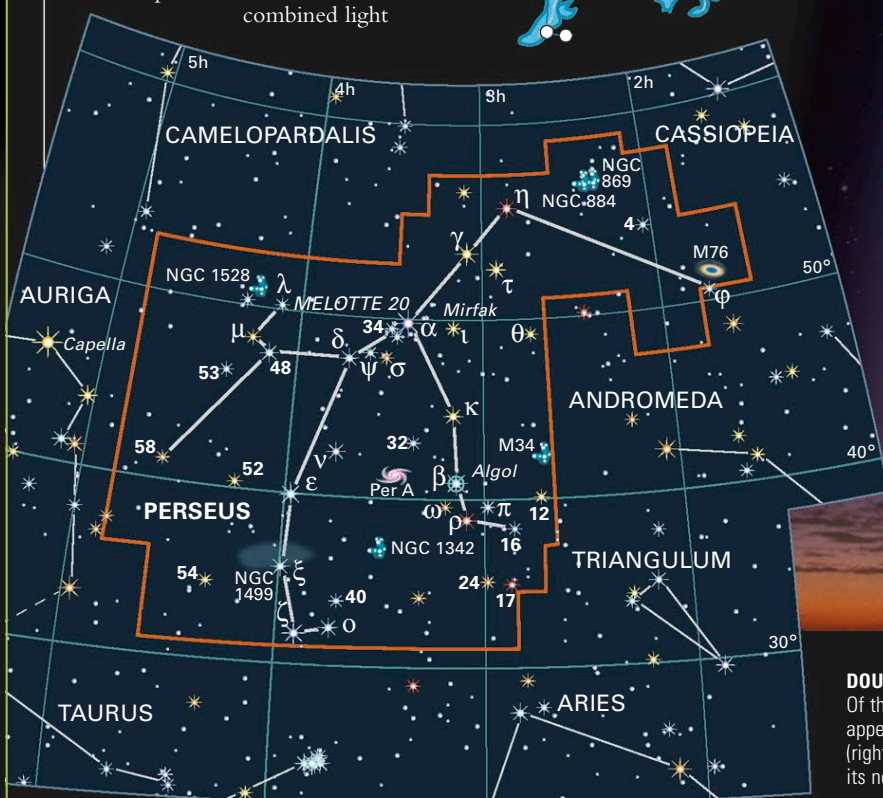
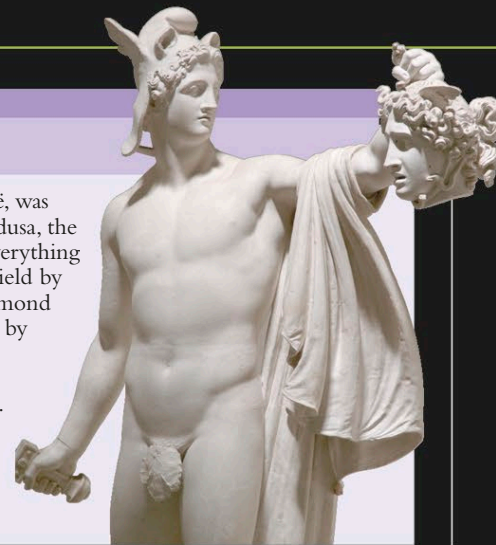
MYTHS AND STORIES

MEDUSA

Perseus, the son of Zeus and Danaë, was sent to bring back the head of Medusa, the Gorgon, whose evil gaze turned everything to stone. He was given a bronze shield by the goddess Athena, a sword of diamond by Hephaestus, and winged sandals by Hermes. Looking only at Medusa's reflection in his shield, Perseus managed to decapitate the Gorgon.

SUCCESSFUL MISSION

Perseus proudly displays the severed head of Medusa, the Gorgon, in this neoclassical sculpture by Antonio Canova.



DOUBLE CLUSTER

Of these two star clusters, NGC 869 (left) appears to be more densely packed. NGC 884 (right) contains some red giant stars, which its neighbor lacks.

